



Cool Solar Cells

Feeling a little hot inside your home after installing solar cells? Here's how to cool them.
<http://dgit.in/Coatcell>



Message @Firefox!

Looking for reasons to shift to Firefox, here's one more to add to your list.
<http://dgit.in/ChatFox>

Feature



Skeuomorphism. More pretty than important.

Skeuomorphism, for the unfortunate reader who did not undertake a career in design, is the style of making digital items and prompts look like their real life counterparts. For example, when a folder icon on the computer looks like a real, physical folder - that's skeuomorphism. When a modern day car has wood panelling applied on its sides to make it look like a vintage car, that's skeuomorphism. When the camera of a phone makes a click sound on taking a picture, a sound it logically does not need to produce now, that's also an example of skeuomorphism.

We don't want pretty anymore. We want something that works. And that is why that designer and that engineer don't look eye-to-eye anymore. A thought that is slowly gaining traction in the design world is that this phase of design is not a phase which will be remembered for its innovation, but of the phase where everyone went "Let's make it simpler" instead of "Let's make it cooler."

But isn't that a good thing? Why on earth would we care about how that facebook logo looks as long as the service still remains the same. Isn't it better when an application opens even 1/4th of a second faster because of a simpler interface? Or look at it the other way round. Nobody wants to wait a second more to open the same service packed in a prettier package.

That doesn't mean that all these tech companies are doing is making their logo mobile-sociable. Take, for example, the heart-attack inducing Oculus Rift's creator Oculus VR. Oculus had a very interesting eye next to it's name in the logo, which signified virtual reality. Unfortunately for it, it also looked like the

ever watchful eye of Big Brother. So they took out the O of Oculus, flattened it, and presented it saying "Here. This is the new logo." The interesting part is, the logo now also looks like a headband, reminiscent of the company's product which made the most noise, the Oculus Rift.

And in one of the saddest but more ingenious logo changes is Quirky, an organisation which serves as a platform for inventors and companies to connect. The company changed its earlier almost scribble like logo to a remix of the symbol '&.' Now when the company has to display on its website a collaboration between an inventor and a company, it says "Inventor '&' Company." That's pretty cool.

Why do brands change logos?

There are more reasons for a brand to change a logo. A brand wants its comical look to be turned into something more serious. A serious look wants to be more friendly. A friendly look wants to be serious too. A friendly look wants to be the brand-next-door type of brand. The list is endless.

A brand will change its logo to give a better idea of what it's products now deliver, or what the brand wants you to think its product now delivers, like how Flipkart changed its logo to reflect a brand which sells a variety of items and not only books. It will change its logo because what was cool yesterday looks lame today, like how Yahoo changed its yodeling font to something a bit cleaner. It will change its logo to reflect possibly a new ownership, like how the font of Motorola's logo looked more 'Googley' when it was acquired by Google, before Lenovo bought it of course. An even more appropriate example of this would be Zomato. Zomato changed its fork and heart logo to a spermesque spoon logo after acquiring the US company Urbanspoon. Why did Zomato change the logo to look like what it acquired? So that the 40 million users of the Urbanspoon would not wake up one day and see some strange app on their phone which they would promptly uninstall - at least it looked similar.

Brands will also change their logo to try to shake off the fact that everybody thinks of them as a dinosaur on an intra-

venous - this is clearly not a reference to AOL's logo change way back in 2009.

Sometimes, however, we stumble across companies which have kept the logo as similar to their original one as they could.

Hewlett Packard has had that familiar 'HP' in its logo for decades. Even after it has decided to split up into two companies, the one handling the computer business still has that iconic 'HP'. IBM too has not made any major changes to its logo since 1947, sticking to its three letters, and since 1971 has stuck to its window-blind look, a look which means speed and dynamism. That is what we were told anyway. Even Intel has



Zomato's current logo

just played around with the placement of its logo since inception, taking the 'inside' outside and sprucing it up a bit. Despite the changes, the feel of the logo and the familiar unfinished circle remained.

So what does it all mean?

Well, an irreverent conclusion is that logos are like clothes. They give an idea about what the company, (or in this metaphor the body if you were paying attention) wants to look like. So does a different outfit really make that much of a difference? Because underneath the shift from pastels to bold or checks to stripes, what matters is whether the garment still fits right and does its innate job of covering the parts you'd like covered. But wait, hold that thought - does only size matter? Don't we always pick that black shirt because it does wonders in covering up that beer belly? Doesn't a Palazzo cut ingeniously cover that skinny frame?

To answer that question, have a look at our previous issues. Did you notice the number of times we changed the logo on our cover page? **4**